

Mississippi State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Middle-tier Power 4 profile with an above-average offensive path and a defense that remains the limiting variable.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 52
Returning production	50% (No. 78) overall · Off. 48% (No. 91) · Def. 53% (No. 69)
Primer power rating	+5.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.7 wins · likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar overall, with a better defensive coaching/portal ceiling but no stable basis yet for a large jump.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC Jeff Lebbey builds around QB Kamario Taylor, RB Fluff Bothwell, WR Anthony Evans III and C Canon Boone, while DC Zach Arnett installs a more aggressive defense. Four unsettled OL jobs and defensive turnover drive the risk.

Bottom line: Mississippi State can stay competitive, but a low-continuity OL/defensive rebuild must survive SP+ SOS No. 12.

Beats expectations if: QB Kamario Taylor stabilizes, the OL settles around C Canon Boone, and DC Zach Arnett improves havoc/explosive-play prevention.

Disappoints if: The OL stays unsettled, QB Kamario Taylor struggles on passing downs, and the rebuilt defense keeps allowing explosives.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Kamario Taylor is the high-confidence projected QB1 after starting the final two games of 2025, but he is still an unproven full-season SEC starter.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was respectable; the bigger problem was a defense that allowed 30.2 points per game and ranked No.124 in explosive-play prevention and No.116 in havoc creation.
- 3 Secondary:** CB Kelley Jones is the roster's clearest nationally recognized star, while S Jahron Manning and EDGE Malick Sylla are not active eligible players in the preseason baseline.
- 4 Coaching:** Jeff Lebbey is the 2026 offensive play-caller and Zach Arnett the defensive play-caller; both assignments are settled for the preseason baseline.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.12, and the post-bye run of at LSU, Oklahoma and at Texas is the schedule's defining stress test.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-8 (1-7 SEC)	● Poor
Scoring	30.4 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	399.2 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	158.0 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	8.06 YPA · 20 TD / 9 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	42.0%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	30.2 PPG allowed	● Poor
Total defense	409.3 YPG allowed	● Poor
Rush defense	186.3 YPG · 4.9 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	223.0 YPG · 7.32 YPA · 24 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Mississippi State's offense was functional and often productive, especially through the air and on third down. The defense was the clear reason the team stayed below .500, struggling badly against the run and in overall yardage prevention.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.97 · No. 52	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.023 · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	43.7% · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	12.0% · No. 68	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	17.7% · No. 115	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.71 · No. 60	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.009 · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	42.8% · No. 82	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.3% · No. 124	● Very poor
Havoc created	13.1% · No. 116	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: The 2025 offense was broadly average to above average by both traditional and play-level measures, but it allowed too much havoc and was only average in explosive-play rate. The defense looked bottom-tier in conventional totals yet closer to average in opponent-adjusted EPA; the real red flags were explosive-play prevention (No.124) and havoc creation (No.116), which explains why modest efficiency could still produce 30.2 points allowed per game.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Jeff Lebby - returning head coach; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Continuity preserves the existing program structure.
DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Zach Arnett - new external hire from Florida State analyst role; defensive play-caller	● ↑ A modest defensive upgrade is plausible from a poor baseline, but heavy personnel turnover keeps the range wide.
Co-DC / linebackers	◆ Matt Brock - program rehire from UConn DC	● ↔ The staff reset adds another transition variable to a defense replacing major personnel.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ OL DJ Chester	LSU	● ↔ One of several material transfer candidates asked to fill four open OL jobs around C Canon Boone.
◆ OL Isaiah Dent	Oklahoma	● ↔ Adds experienced competition to a line with major turnover; exact starting role remains unsettled.
◆ WR Marquis Johnson	Missouri	● ↔ Major-role candidate who helps replace departed receiver volume without a locked target share.
◆ WR Zion Ragins	Oklahoma	● ↔ Provides rotation competition in a receiver room that remains open behind WR Anthony Evans III.
◆ QB AJ Swann	App State	● ↔ Experienced backup depth behind QB Kamario Taylor rather than a supported starter projection.

Out	To	Loss
WR Brenen Thompson	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 4, No. 105	● ↓ Major 2025 receiver departs via Round 4 NFL draft selection.
TE Seydou Traore	NFL (Miami), Round 5, No. 180	● ↓ Significant tight-end contributor departs via Round 5 NFL draft selection.
OL Albert Reese IV	NFL (Carolina), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran starting lineman leaves via UDFA signing.
OL Trevor Mayberry	Undrafted; Tampa Bay rookie-minicamp tryout	● ↓ Material 2025 OL starter completed college career and had a Tampa Bay rookie-minicamp tryout; no active NFL contract is asserted.
OL Jacoby Jackson	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Another veteran multi-year starting lineman completed his collegiate career; no professional destination is established.
WR Jordan Mosley	Colorado State	● ↔ Five-start 2025 receiver departs; the Colorado State destination.

Offense net: Similar performance ceiling with materially lower continuity, especially on the line. ● ↔

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Jayson Jenkins	Florida State	● ↑ Projected major front role in the attempt to upgrade a poor 2025 defense.
◆ EDGE Amaree Williams	Florida State	● ↑ Expected major edge role and important athletic addition to Arnett's attacking front.
◆ S Jardin Gilbert	LSU	● ↔ Material secondary addition in a room replacing several experienced defenders.
◆ S Kendel Dolby	Oklahoma	● ↔ Adds experienced competition to a secondary with substantial turnover.
◆ LB James Heard Jr.	Syracuse	● ↔ Provides front-seven depth as the linebacker group replaces multiple contributors.

Out	To	Loss
CB DeAgo Brumfield	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ A 12-start 2025 corner departs after pursuing the NFL; no NFL signing is established.
S Brylan Lanier	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ An 11-start safety with 67 tackles and four interceptions completed his collegiate career.
LB Nic Mitchell	Undrafted; Denver rookie-minicamp tryout	● ↓ High-volume 2025 linebacker contributor leaves after a Denver rookie-minicamp tryout path.
LB Branden Jennings	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ A 12-start JACK completed his collegiate career.

Out	To	Loss
DL Kedrick Bingley-Jones	Alabama	● ↓ Material transfer departure from a front already needing improvement.
LB Tony Mitchell	Ole Miss	● ↓ Meaningful linebacker transfer departure adds to front-seven turnover.

Defense net: Modest upgrade projection from a poor baseline, but with a very wide range because so much of the front and back end is new. ● ↑

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Lebby offense built around QB Kamario Taylor's development, a run-game priority and a veteran lead receiver.	RB Fluff Bothwell/WR Anthony Evans III/C Canon Boone give the offense proven centerpieces, and 2025 efficiency was broadly average.	Four OL jobs remain unsettled and the 2025 offense ranked No.115 in havoc allowed.
Defense	Arnett wants an aggressive, attacking unit that affects the quarterback and creates negative plays.	CB Kelley Jones and S Isaac Smith plus LB Zakari Tillman provide a few proven anchors and the portal class raises the athletic ceiling.	The 2025 defense allowed too many explosives and created too little havoc, while 2026 roles are heavily rebuilt.
Special teams	Experienced returning specialist operation.	K Kyle Ferrie and P Ethan Pulliam both return with recognition and SP+ ranks the unit No.21.	No material specialist uncertainty is established at the cutoff; performance still requires normal late availability changes.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	The established returning starter stabilizes an offense with substantial change around him.
RB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	A rebuilt backfield replaces major 2025 production with returning and transfer options.
WR	● B	● ↔	Medium	Returning production plus transfers provide options, but the hierarchy is materially changed.
TE	● C	● ↓	Low	The room has experience but limited proven continuity at the top.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	Returning starters provide a base, though departures and role competition keep the ceiling uncertain.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	Transfer additions offset major front departures and important availability losses.
LB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	A reshaped linebacker group must replace substantial 2025 tackle and start volume.
Secondary	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	Transfer additions rebuild a secondary that loses significant veteran production.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	High	Core specialist roles are defined without a major preseason edge.
Coaching	● B	● ↑	Medium	HC Jeff Lebby retains offensive continuity while defensive staff changes add uncertainty.
Overall	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	Middle-tier Power 4 profile with an above-average offensive path; defense remains the limiting variable.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Kelley Jones	CB	● Nationally recognized star / high-end conference starter	Walter Camp 1st · AP 2nd · SEC Coaches second team · SEC Media second team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Thorpe	The clearest proven star on a defense otherwise undergoing major turnover.
Anthony Evans III	WR	● High-end conference starter	Biletnikoff · Paul Hornung	Led Mississippi State in 2025 with 67 catches and 831 yards and is the safest returning receiving anchor.
Kamario Taylor	QB	● Unproven starter / breakout candidate	-	Started the final two 2025 games and is the high-confidence projected QB1; his development controls the offense's ceiling.
Canon Boone	C	● Solid conference starter / line anchor	Rimington	Started all 13 games in 2025 and is the only firmly established OL anchor while four jobs remain open.
Fluff Bothwell	RB	● Solid conference starter	-	Returns after a team-high 677 rushing yards and six touchdowns and gives the run game a known lead option.
Zakari Tillman	LB	● Proven returning starter	-	Returns after 10 starts and 47 tackles, supplying needed continuity in a rebuilt front seven.
◆ Jayson Jenkins (TR: Florida State)	DL	● Projected major transfer role	-	One of the most important transfer-front candidates in Arnett's attempt to improve the defense.
Kyle Ferrie	K	● Established specialist strength	Lou Groza	Returns as the placekicker on an SP+ top-25 special-teams unit.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Very hard; Mississippi State has only a few rating-band opportunities and must protect them to reach bowl range.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 12
Hardest stretch	at LSU → Oklahoma → at Texas
Swing games	at Minnesota, Vanderbilt, Auburn
Advantage	ULM and Tennessee Tech are home nonconference games, while Vanderbilt and Auburn also come to Starkville.
Expected	4.7 wins · likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The No. 37 SP+ offense offers upside, but defensive volatility and schedule quality argue against a clean sleeper case.
Back them when	Catching useful points after the OL stabilizes and QB Kamario Taylor is playing efficiently.
Fade/pass when	Pass or lean away against explosive offenses or strong pressure fronts until Mississippi State proves it can prevent chunk plays defensively and protect a low-continuity line.
Key monitor	Final OL five, QB Kamario Taylor under SEC pressure, S Jahron Manning/EDGE Malick Sylla eligibility, defensive explosives/havoc and transfer-front roles.
Week 1 baseline	Mississippi State -36.0 vs. UL-Monroe · rating-only baseline; Mississippi State primer +5.0 minus final preseason SP+ proxy UL-Monroe -28.9 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Mississippi State -28.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Mississippi State has a stable starting quarterback and enough offensive continuity to be more functional, but the surrounding skill/line hierarchy still carries meaningful transition. The defense is more transfer-dependent and has important front-seven availability questions.

The upside case requires the offense to stay efficient while the rebuilt defense becomes merely competent. The baseline remains **4.7 wins • likely 5-7**; roster health and defensive-role clarity are the biggest variables rather than any assumption of an automatic Year 3 leap.

About this primer

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